

Why Endpoint Data Alone is Not Enough for an Effective XDR Strategy

 fidelissecurity.com/threatgeek/xdr-security/effective-xdr-strategy

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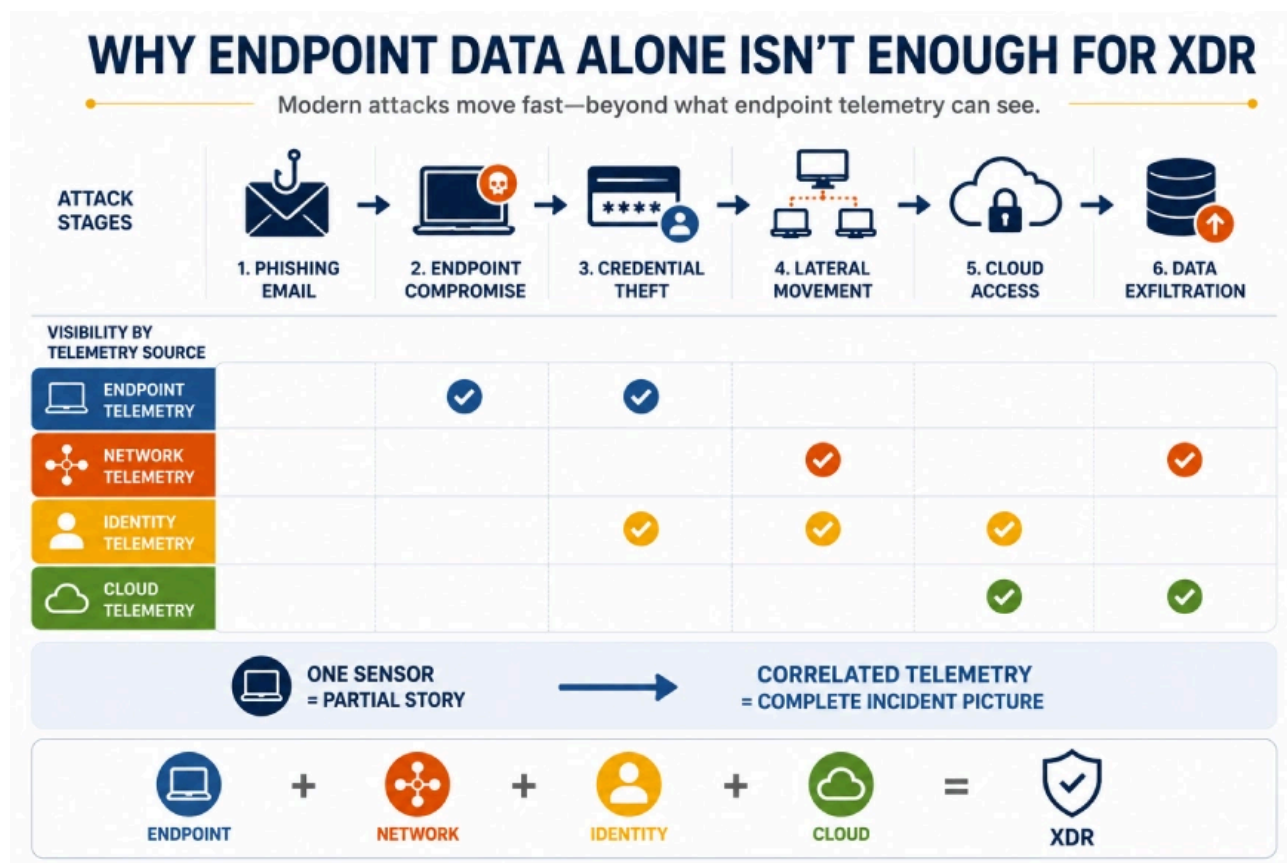


Key Takeaways

- Endpoints are where most attacks start. That doesn't make endpoint data enough to build an XDR strategy around on its own.
- EDRKillShifter, EDRSilencer, and EDRSandblast aren't evasion tools. They're built to kill the endpoint agent outright.
- Lateral movement, Unmanaged devices, Identity compromise and Cloud activity, none of them shows up if the endpoint is your only sensor.
- Collecting endpoint, network, identity, and cloud data isn't the hard part. Correlating it into one incident picture is what actually makes an XDR strategy work.
- Fidelis Elevate[®] ties Fidelis Endpoint[®], Fidelis Network[®], Active Directory Intercept[™], and Fidelis Deception[®] together in one platform: correlated detection, automated response across all four.

Why Do Security Teams Rely So Heavily on Endpoint Data in the

First Place?



Can Attackers Disable or Evade Endpoint Detection Tools?

Yes, and this is the part of the endpoint-data conversation that gets skipped most often. It isn't only that endpoint agents miss activity happening elsewhere. Attackers have built tools specifically to blind or kill the endpoint agent itself.

Security researchers have documented a growing category of “EDR killer” tools, including EDRKillShifter, EDRSilencer, EDRSandblast, variants of Terminator, and even the legitimate business application HRSword repurposed for the same job. These tools exploit the fact that any endpoint agent runs on the same operating system the attacker controls, contesting its visibility, disabling its drivers, or terminating its processes outright. Because EDR deployments tend to be uniform across environments, an exploit that defeats one installation tends to work everywhere that same agent runs.

A CISA Red Team assessment of a US critical infrastructure organization put this plainly. The team maintained access for months and reached its objectives, and the top lesson learned was that the organization had insufficient technical controls to prevent and detect malicious activity because it relied too heavily on host-based EDR without enough network-layer protection.

This is the sharpest argument against treating endpoint detection and response security event data as sufficient on its own. It isn't just incomplete, it's a target. Any XDR security

strategy built entirely on a sensor the attacker can disable has a single point of failure baked into its foundation.



What Threats Does Endpoint-Only Monitoring Miss?

Even when the endpoint agent runs exactly as intended, its view stops at the device. Several categories of activity live almost entirely outside that view.

Lateral movement is the clearest example. Once inside, attackers increasingly use stolen credentials and legitimate system tools to move between machines, activity that shows up far more clearly through [network detection and response \(NDR\)](#) than in any single endpoint's process tree.

Unmanaged and unagentable devices are another gap. IoT devices, legacy systems, and some BYOD endpoints often cannot run an EDR agent at all, so they're invisible to endpoint-based detection by design, not by failure.

Identity is a third blind spot. Credential theft, [privilege escalation](#), and Active Directory compromise sit at the center of most modern breach chains, and these are identity events, not endpoint events.

Cloud security is the fourth: as infrastructure spreads across multi-cloud and hybrid environments, a growing share of what happens to an organization's data happens entirely

off any managed endpoint, which is exactly why cloud XDR coverage matters as much as endpoint coverage.

None of these gaps are a flaw in EDR. They sit outside its job description. The mistake is asking one sensor to answer questions an effective XDR strategy needs answered elsewhere.

Does Your XDR Have the Data Needed for High-Confidence Detection?

Gartner's shorthand for XDR: a platform that automatically collects and correlates data from multiple security components. Two verbs, two very different levels of difficulty. Collecting is the easy half. Correlating, actually using that mix of endpoint, network, identity, email, and cloud data to catch something real, is where most deployments quietly fall apart. Detect, prioritize, automate the response. Simple to describe. Hard to run.

Here's why the correlation part matters so much. Say a phishing email lands and someone clicks it. A credential gets stolen off the back of that click. The stolen credential turns up moving between machines on the network. Not long after, data starts flowing out through a cloud app. Four separate signals, spread across four systems. Looked at individually, none of them scream "breach." Lined up next to each other, they tell one clear story about an intrusion in progress.

A platform watching only the endpoint sees the first signal and stops there. It has nothing else to line it up against, so all it can do is get incrementally better at spotting the same kind of thing it already spots. That's EDR wearing an XDR badge. It isn't extended detection and response security in any meaningful sense.

Ask this instead when evaluating an XDR strategy: forget the volume of endpoint data coming in. Is there enough range across sources, endpoint, network, identity, and cloud to actually back a high-confidence call the moment an alert fires?

Building an XDR Strategy That Goes Beyond Endpoint Data

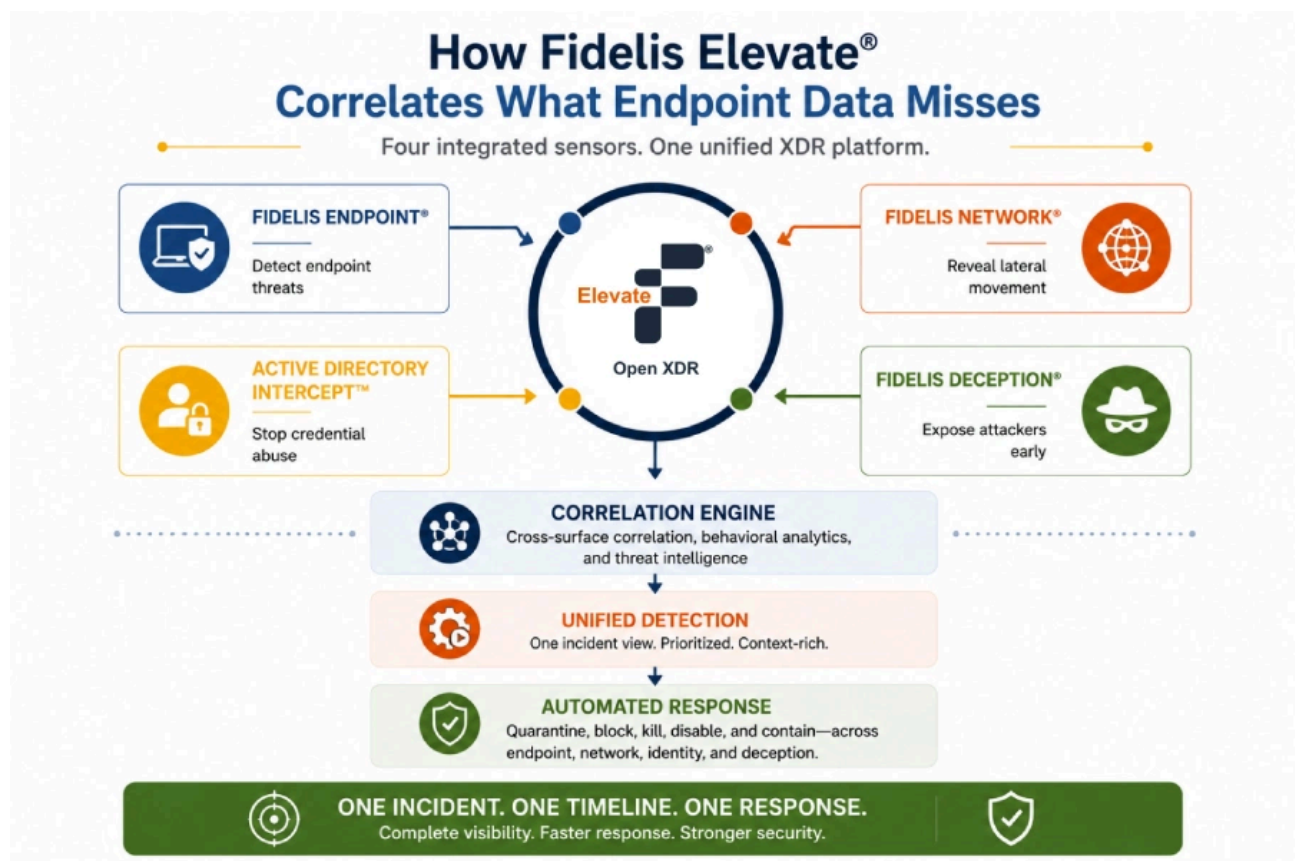
Start with where the data comes from. Network traffic, identity and Active Directory logs, cloud workload data, email telemetry, none of that should show up as an afterthought once endpoint data has already been flowing for months. Treat it as a first-class input from day one of XDR deployment. Waiting until an incident exposes the gap is how most of these gaps get found in the first place.

Getting the data in the door solves nothing by itself. A data lake full of raw telemetry doesn't detect a single thing on its own. Someone has to apply correlation rules, [behavioral analytics](#), and machine learning across every source, consistently, so a suspicious login

sitting next to a suspicious network connection actually gets read as one event instead of two nobody bothers to connect.

Then there's response, and this is the piece most XDR best practices lists skip over. Automation has to reach every domain the platform touches, not stop at the endpoint. Isolating a compromised device is a reasonable first move. It won't matter much if the attacker already has a foothold in the network or a compromised Active Directory account sitting untouched. [XDR incident response](#) only works if it covers as much ground as detection does.

How Does Fidelis Elevate® Solve the Endpoint Data Problem?



[Fidelis Network](#)® performs session-level inspection across all 65,535 network ports, giving the platform genuine network detection and response coverage that catches lateral movement and command-and-control traffic regardless of whether the device involved is running an agent at all. This closes exactly the gap that EDR-killer tools try to exploit. [Active Directory Intercept](#)™ covers the identity layer directly, watching for the credential theft and privilege escalation that sit at the center of most breach chains.

[Fidelis Deception](#)® adds cyber deception assets, decoys that reveal an attacker's presence and intent before they reach anything of real value, which matters most in the exact scenario the CISA Red Team report describes: an attacker with quiet, sustained access that endpoint monitoring alone never surfaced.

All of it correlates through one platform, so an analyst isn't manually connecting an endpoint alert to a network alert to an identity alert. Fidelis Elevate® can also automatically quarantine a compromised system, freeze network traffic, kill a malicious process, and disable a compromised administrator account as a single coordinated response, rather than requiring a human to stitch that sequence together mid-incident.

What Should an Effective XDR Strategy Actually Include?

Endpoint data is a strong foundation, not a complete XDR strategy. It's necessary because that's where most attacks start, and it's insufficient because attackers now treat the endpoint agent itself as a target, and because a large share of what a modern breach touches, network movement, identity abuse, cloud activity, never crosses that one sensor's view.

An effective XDR strategy needs telemetry that doesn't depend on a single host staying uncompromised, a platform that correlates across that telemetry rather than just storing it, and [response automation](#) that reaches every domain an attacker can touch. Fidelis Elevate® was built to deliver exactly that: endpoint, network, identity, and deception, unified and correlated in one platform, so a compromised or disabled endpoint agent is a setback, not a blind spot.

The image is a stylized graphic of a hand holding a datasheet. The hand is composed of dark blue rounded rectangular segments. The 'index' finger holds a white document titled 'Fidelis Elevate Datasheet'. The document contains the following text:

DATA SHEET

Fidelis Elevate
Think Like the Adversary.

Everything about modern compute environment... massive digital transformation initiatives... surfaces. Data is everywhere. Adversaries go... sophisticated and profile. The only part of this... the same or similar are the staff and resources... have in place to combat cyber attacks. That's... seamless, and integrated security operations... cyber readiness. And that's where Fidelis Elevate.

How Fidelis Elevate Works

Fidelis Elevate is the powerhouse of your SIEM and your security stack. This open and agile... and Response (XDR) platform is purpose-built... defense. Fidelis Elevate provides contextual... detection to speed threat detection, handle... the entire environment. Fidelis Elevate gets... security intelligence for IT, IoT, data center... single view. Security defenders can quickly... perform deep inspection and analysis of g... business continuity through an attack, an... normal business operations as quickly as...

Fidelis Elevate
Open XDR Built

Fidelis Elevate
Think Like the Adversary.
Be Ready for Anything.

Datasheet

Frequently Asked Questions

What is an XDR strategy?

An XDR strategy is a plan for collecting and correlating security data from multiple sources, endpoint, network, identity, cloud, and email, into one platform that detects threats faster and automates response across all of them, rather than relying on any single tool.

Is EDR enough on its own for threat detection?

No. EDR provides strong visibility into managed endpoints, but it can't see network-only activity, identity compromise, or cloud events, and attackers increasingly target the EDR agent itself to disable it during an attack.

Can attackers actually disable or bypass EDR tools?

Yes. Documented tools like EDRKillShifter, EDRSilencer, and EDRSandblast are built specifically to disable endpoint agents, and a CISA Red Team assessment found an organization compromised for months partly because it relied too heavily on host-based EDR without network-layer protection.

What data sources should a strong XDR strategy include?

At minimum, endpoint, network, identity and Active Directory, cloud workload, and email telemetry. Excluding any one of these leaves a gap that correlates directly to a category of attacks that the sensor alone can't detect.

How does Fidelis Elevate® support an XDR strategy?

Fidelis Elevate® unifies Fidelis Endpoint®, Fidelis Network®, Active Directory Intercept™, and Fidelis Deception® into a single platform with correlated detection and automated response across all four, rather than treating endpoint as the primary sensor and the rest as add-ons.